

Before You Say Yes to the Dog



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FREE PRACTICAL GUIDE · PRINT OR USE ON SCREEN

The Puppy Starter Pack



Four practical tools before, during and after day one

Choosing the puppy, preparing the house, getting through the first 48 hours, and knowing what to do when something goes wrong.



A free guide from the two books.

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Families do not usually fail because they stopped loving the dog

They fail because the house never had a plan. The dream is emotional. The workload is real. Dreams do not clean up accidents or stop a puppy biting. They do not protect the comfort of the person who never asked for a dog. They do not wake at night, manage the potty trips, hold the gate, handle the visitors, or call the vet.

Who is telling you this

You are about to spend time listening to me, so you deserve to know why my opinion is worth it. I am not a dog trainer. I have never run a kennel, titled a dog in obedience, or stood in a show ring. I am a father, and long before that I was a young man who loved one dog completely.

His name was Guru. I had him when I was single and working, with no children, no school mornings, and no one else's comfort to protect. Caring for him was simple, because the only life he had to fit into was mine. When he died the bond stayed with me, and so did a picture of my own children one day growing up beside a dog of their own. Years later I tried to make that picture real. And I failed. Not once, but three times, in my own home, with my own children watching.

That is where most people stop and blame bad luck, the wrong breed, or a bad season. I did something different, because solving difficult problems is what I do for a living. I treated the dog the way I would treat a business that keeps losing money despite everyone's good intentions. I did not ask, "How do I train this puppy?" I asked a harder question: "Why does a family that loves dogs keep failing with them?"

Slowly the answer came into focus, and it surprised me. The missing piece had never been love; we had plenty of that. It was not training either. The missing piece was a system, and it had almost nothing to do with the dog.

So when I tell you what works, understand where it comes from. I am not handing you theory I read somewhere. I am handing you something I paid for three times, in chaos, in guilt, and in a rehoming I still regret.

"Sometimes the dog was trained, but the house was not."

from the introduction to Before You Say Yes to the Dog

Training works on the dog. The system works on the people.

Training can teach a dog where to toilet. Only a system answers the question that actually decides success: who takes the puppy to that place every hour? Who does it at seven in the morning before the school run, at eleven while you are in a meeting, at three when only the children are home, and at midnight when the whole house is asleep?

That is why a perfectly trained dog can still wreck a household. A trainer can teach the dog almost anything. No one can be hired to run your family for you.



THE REALITY CHECK

Six jobs. Write a name against each.

Not “we”. A name. This takes two minutes and it is the fastest honest read you can get on whether your household is ready.

The job	Who owns it
7am, before the school run	
11am, when the house is at work	
3pm, when only the children are home	
Midnight	
The accident nobody saw happen	
Holding the line when the least-ready person says no	

How to read what you just wrote

- ◆ Every line has a name, and no name appears more than three times. Your household is sharing the load. Use the tools.
- ◆ One name carries four or more lines. That person is the system. When they are ill, travelling, or simply tired, the system stops.
- ◆ Any line says “we”, or is blank. That job has no owner. A job with no name does not get done at three in the morning.

If that exercise was uncomfortable, nothing has gone wrong. Most families have never been asked the question in that form. The discomfort is the useful part — it is far cheaper to feel it now, on a page, than in month three with the puppy already home.

THE JOURNEY

Four stages, in the order they happen

These are the four moments that are hardest to reverse: the puppy you choose, the house he walks into, the first two days, and the emergency you hope never comes. Print them and write on them, or keep them on screen.



BEFORE YOU SAY YES

Choose fit, not fantasy

The puppy your family can actually raise, not the most impressive one in the litter. No puppy is chosen because the kids fell in love in five minutes.

Fit-and-Lifestyle Check

Answer for a normal week, not your best week.

Hours the dog is alone on a weekday	
Who walks him before / after work	
Daily active time we can give (minutes)	
Home type / garden (yes or no)	
Comfortable monthly budget	
Energy level we can match	
Weekly grooming time we will do	

Vetting and red flags

Ask every question. There will always be another puppy.

- ◆ Can I see the puppy with its mother and littermates?
- ◆ Are health checks, vaccinations, and worming documented?
- ◆ Will you take the dog back if it does not work out?

Walk away or pause if: records refused, puppy sick or lethargic, pressure to pay fast, aggression is the selling point, puppy extremely fearful or intense, age unclear, vet check refused, or the environment is unsafe or filthy.

Meet the litter

You are choosing a temperament, not a colour.

- ◆ Approaches people calmly — neither frozen nor frantic
- ◆ Recovers quickly from a noise or a dropped object
- ◆ Accepts gentle handling of paws and ears
- ◆ Plays hard, then settles
- ◆ Be cautious choosing the boldest or the most fearful of the litter

BEFORE HE ARRIVES

Prepare the house

The puppy should arrive into a prepared system, not a random space. Build the map first — zones, supplies, gates — then bring the puppy into it.

“If every place is play, the puppy will play everywhere.”

Decide your zones, before buying anything

Sleep / crate (BOX) location	
POTTY corner	
Settle spot (PLACE)	
Food and water area	
Puppy-free rooms	
Garden play zone	
Garden calm zone	
SAFE space for the least-ready person	

Supplies

☐	Crate and bed sized for the adult dog
☐	Gates for stairs and puppy-free zones
☐	Bowls and age-appropriate food
☐	Collar, harness, two leads, ID tag
☐	Chew toys and enrichment
☐	Enzyme cleaner for accidents, and poop bags
☐	Basic grooming kit
☐	Vet chosen and first appointment booked

Puppy-proofing

☐	Secure or hide cables and wires
☐	Remove reachable toxic plants and foods
☐	Latch low cupboards — cleaners, medicines
☐	Close gaps in the fence and garden boundary
☐	Clear anything swallowable at floor level
☐	Agree door and gate rules so no one lets the puppy bolt



WHEN HE ARRIVES

Keep the first 48 hours boring and controlled

The first 48 hours are not for proving how much the family loves the puppy. They are for teaching the puppy how the house works. The puppy enters routine before freedom — the first two days should be smaller, calmer, and more boring than the family wants.

Who does what

- ◆ Lead adult — controls arrival, first entry, the first night, the no-visitor rule, the freedom level, accidents, and the SAFE response.
- ◆ Kids — quiet voices, stand still, help track POTTY, report sniffing, circling, biting, or crying. No chasing.
- ◆ Least-ready person (SAFE) — does not need to train or interact. Their comfort is protected from Day 0, and they can call “BOX NOW” at any time.
- ◆ Puppy — learns the POTTY place, BOX, PLACE, sleep, water, calm contact, and the limits of the house.

Arrival, day 0

Quiet entry, no welcome party, no visitors. Straight to the POTTY spot first. Then a calm look at the BOX and PLACE, then rest. The puppy meets the system, not a crowd.

The first night

Keep the night boring: POTTY only, no play, no party. Expect crying — it is normal. Short, calm POTTY trips when needed, then straight back to the BOX. You are not being cruel; you are being predictable.

Potty timing

Take the puppy to the same POTTY spot after waking, after eating, after play, and every 60–90 minutes awake. Reward calmly when it works. Clean accidents with enzyme cleaner and move on — timing and tracking, never punishment.

Biting

Treat biting as tiredness and excitement, not badness. Redirect to a chew. If it sharpens, end the game and offer rest. The answer is almost always more rest, not more correction.

SAFE from day 0

The least-ready person never has to enforce anything. They say “BOX NOW,” and the lead adult makes it happen. Comfort is protected before it is tested — that is what makes the whole system hold.

First 48 hours, quick checklist

☐	Zones and supplies ready before pickup
☐	First POTTY trip the moment you arrive
☐	No visitors for 48 hours
☐	Night = POTTY only, no play
☐	Track every POTTY
☐	Accidents cleaned, not punished
☐	SAFE call respected instantly

The First 48 Hours is one of the manuals in After You Say Yes to the Dog.

WHEN SOMETHING GOES WRONG

Separate. Call. Go.

This does not make you a vet. It helps your family act fast, safely, and clearly. When serious signs appear, call your vet or emergency clinic.

The rule

- ◆ Separate the puppy from the danger.
- ◆ Call the lead adult, the backup adult, or the vet.
- ◆ Go to the clinic if instructed, or if it looks serious.

Act now — do not wait and see

- ◆ Breathing trouble or collapse
- ◆ Suspected poisoning
- ◆ Bloat signs — swollen, hard belly; retching with nothing coming up
- ◆ Heavy bleeding
- ◆ Severe heat signs
- ◆ Seizure or sudden severe weakness
- ◆ Swallowed a foreign object

Have ready before you need it

Vet phone number	
Emergency clinic, 24-hour	
Route to the clinic saved	
Who drives / who holds the dog	

The children's rule

- ◆ Kids never handle vomit, blood, wounds, poison, medicine, or the dog's mouth.
- ◆ A child's only job in an emergency is to get an adult, fast.

Please read. This is a family-readiness and educational resource. It is not a substitute for professional veterinary, medical, behavioural, training, or legal advice, and it does not establish any professional relationship. Always consult a qualified veterinarian or certified professional for your dog's specific needs, and never leave young children unsupervised with a dog. Living with a dog carries inherent risks; neither the author nor the publisher assumes responsibility for any loss, injury, or damage arising from the use or misuse of the information here. Results vary from family to family and dog to dog.

The question was never which puppy

Four tools will help you choose well, prepare properly, and survive the first two days. But if the reality check landed, you already know the pack has exposed a bigger question than the one you arrived with.

It was never really which puppy to choose. It is whether your family — this house, this schedule, these children, and the one person who feels least ready — can carry the life that comes with one.

“Never go to war before winning the battle on a piece of paper.”

the business quote the author keeps on his desk

Win the decision on paper first. Then live it. That is what the first book is for, and it ends where this pack cannot: at an honest test you score as a family, which gives you one of three answers — now, later, or never. Each one, given honestly, is a good answer.

When I ran this test on my own family, the answer came back not yet. My daughter wanted a dog so badly that she cried real tears for one. But when she saw what saying yes actually meant — the daily workload, the first-week pressure, the jobs she and her siblings would have to carry, her mother’s comfort boundaries, the cleaning, the broken sleep — she paused. We did not say no to the dog. We did not say yes either. We postponed the decision by one year. And when the year had passed and we were ready, the puppy did not arrive first. The system arrived first. Choosing to wait is the single decision that made everything afterward succeed.

Before You Say Yes to the Dog

The decision before the decision.

The real workload before it lands on one person. Who actually does what, including the kids. A real say for whoever feels least ready. The reset, for families who already said yes. It ends at the Family Readiness Test, which gives one of three answers — now, later, or never. Each one, given honestly, is a good answer.

After You Say Yes to the Dog

The operating manual after the decision.

One manual per pressure moment: the first 48 hours, potty, socialization, night barking, visitors, outdoor freedom, grooming, emergencies, and the reset. Printable routines and trackers you use on the day, not read about.

Keep getting practical tools

New checklists, printable routines and practical notes connected to the books go out to subscribers first. No daily emails. No constant promotions. Just useful material when there is something worth sending. Subscribe at mohamedabukhadra.com